nasty things to us both on and off the field. Shopkeepers swore at us. Waiters in restaurants passed comments. On top of that, when we lost two ODIs soon after the scandal erupted, even the Pakistani supporters stopped coming in to watch our matches.

Still, we tried to fight on, and won two ODIs against England despite the absence of our three main players – they were suspended as the investigation began on the sidelines of the series. We won at Lord's, our biggest game in England, despite everything falling apart around us. We could have even won the series, had it not been for a dropped catch by Mohammad Yousuf in the last match. Still, by the end of the series, we got a lot of pats on our back for bringing some respect back to the team and the game because of the way we played, in spite of the allegations against our players. The victories weren't much consolation, though. Being on that tour was like being in hell.

It's easy to say that there's enough money in international cricket today that you don't have to resort to such illegal activities. It's also easy to say that you reap what you sow, and that those guys got what they deserved. But there's always context to clichés.

Things were going well for those players. They had county contracts coming up in England. They had captaincies and sponsorships coming up in Pakistan. Thus, what they did was an insult to us, to the game and to the country.

Temptation comes easily with the way the modern game has evolved and the way commercial interests are aligned with it. To be perfectly honest, Mazhar Majeed and his brother Azhar had approached me a few times when I was on tour, yet I stayed away from them because I knew they were trouble. I just went ahead and did my own thing. I never knew till much later what they were capable of. All I knew was that they were sending out all the wrong signals. Thus, as alleged by the supporters of the accused, I don't think anybody got 'trapped' in the scheme. They were all fully cognizant volunteers.

The same goes for Danish Kaneria, the spinner from Karachi who was caught in a county cricket corruption controversy, also in England. Danish is a good kid, but after I heard about his involvement in corruption from so many sources, including then PCB chairman Ijaz Butt, I couldn't help but believe the old saying: where there's smoke, there's fire.

Also, there's a school of thought that the uber-talented Mohammad Amir should never have been allowed back in the game. There are people who think that he ruined a great game – the greatest game of all, really – and let his country down. There are people who think that if you can vote at eighteen and can get married at eighteen, then you can be banned for life for being a cheat in the game of cricket at eighteen too.

But Amir never lied. He never lied to me when I caught on to what Butt was cooking. He never lied to the court when it came to the probe. He never lied to the media. In fact, he was ready to face questions.

Salman Butt, however, was the opposite. He lied through his teeth. Also – and this is why he really hurt me – he was the *captain*. He was supposed to *lead*. As skipper, he was supposed to take the fall. He could have apologized. He never did. Not just to me, but to the fans of Pakistan cricket. That's not what a true leader does. A real leader knows when to bow out.

As for Amir, yes, he was young. But he was old enough too. This has always been the argument from those who think he should not have been forgiven.

But remember: this is Pakistan. We've never set a great example, be it in cricket or in our